25900372 MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) Regular EXAMINATION October 2025

THIRD SEMESTER

Discipline Specific Core Course (DSC) - MG3DSCENG202 - **DETECTIVE FICTION**

(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Duration: 2 Hours Maximum Marks: 70

Scheme of Valuation

Part A

MCQ

Answer all questions. Each question carries 1 mark.

1. b) Thrillers and spy stories [U] / [CO1]
2. a) Sudden plot twist without explanation [U] / [CO2]
3. c). A sentence about the Name [U] / [CO3]
4. a). Best Original Screenplay [A] / [CO3]
5. b). Holmes, Inspector French, Father Brown [K] / [CO1]
6. b). By substituting the letter with another one [U] / [CO2]
7. c). A gangster named Cassetti [K] / [CO3]
8. c). Paddy field [K] / [CO3]
9. a). Accident or suicide [K] / [CO1]
10. b). To avoid detection [K] / [CO2]

[1x10 = 10]

Part B

SHORT ANSWER

Answer any 6 questions. Each question carries 5 marks.

11. Poirot presents two solutions in *Murder on the Orient Express* to balance truth with morality. The first - a mysterious stranger committed the murder - offers a simple, lawful explanation. The second - all twelve passengers killed Ratchett to avenge Daisy Armstrong - reveals the moral truth behind the crime. Poirot, aware that strict justice would only punish those who sought to right a great wrong, gives both versions to let M. Bouc and Dr. Constantine choose between legal duty and moral conscience - upholds both truth and humanity, allowing justice to take a compassionate form. [An] / [CO3]
12. Holmes - sharp and detached, Watson - warm and grounded. Watson's empathy complements Sherlock's intellect, relationship - based on deep trust, becomes the foundation of their adventures - Watson's presence softens Holmes's cold intellect and letsreaders/ viewers see the man behind the mind. [U] / [CO3]
13. Freeman says theologians, scholars, and lawyers love detective fiction because it offers intellectual satisfaction. They enjoy solving logical problems, just as they do in their work. They like reasoning, argument, and the discovery of truth. [A] / [CO1]

14. **Moderately lenient evaluation recommended.** In “Kailash Chowdhury’s Jewel,” the jewel stands as a) Symbol of Pride and Status, b) Emblem of Greed and Human Weakness, c) Representation of Illusion and Deception, d) Metaphor for Inner Value vs. Outer Glitter, d) Catalyst that reflects human nature and ethical truth**.** [U] / [CO2]
15. Hercule Poirot - a professional Belgian sleuth - characterised by his moustache-twirling, egg-shaped head and his methodical approach, emphasising method, order, and little grey cells - identifies himself as an international detective who belongs to the world and emphasises a cosmopolitan perspective - characters in the novel say that he has a knack for finding things out and that it is not easy to hide things from him - solves mysteries with careful thought and close observation rather than force [A] / [CO3]
16. Yavanika’s narrative rhythm - alternates between rehearsals and performance of the play “Black and White” by Bhavana theatre troupe and the grim pace of the investigation by Inspector Jacob - Performance and reality overlap as both hide secrets beneath the surface - investigation slowly removes the mask, exposes the underlying elements of performance and truth, finally reveals the person behind Ayyappan’s murder. [U]/[CO3]
17. Van Dine says a detective story must depend on logical deduction, not luck. Coincidence weakens the story, but logic keeps it honest and fair - makes detective fiction feel like a real contest of minds between writer and reader. [A] / [CO1]
18. Watson’s narration humanizes Holmes - mediates the detective’s detached logic – Because Watson tells the story, we see Holmes through a friend’s admiring eyes - his limited understanding keeps the mystery alive, and his warmth makes Holmes’s brilliance easier to appreciate. [U] / [CO2]
19. **Lenient evaluation recommended.** Borges uses carnival scenes to blur truth and Illusion - bright, playful setting - spiral staircase, rhomboid diamonds on windows, duplicate patios, mirrors - hides danger and confusion, showing how logic can fail when the world itself becomes a mask. [E] / [CO3]

[5x 6 = 30]

Part C

ESSAY

Answer **any 2** questions. Each question carries 15 marks.

20. **Moderately lenient evaluation recommended**. Borges writes “Death and the Compass” as a detective story that also questions human reason. Borges begins with a detective story — a murder, clues, and a clever investigator — but turns it into a reflection on reason and fate. Detective Lönnrot follows logic so perfectly that it traps him and leads him to death. His search for order becomes a journey into error and walks into the logical labyrinth set by Scharlach. Borges uses the detective form to ask deeper questions about knowledge, destiny, and the limits of reason. Borges shows that reason can become a trap and that truth may lie beyond logic. What reads like a mystery becomes a meditation on how our need for meaning and over-reliance on intellect can lead to destruction. Thus, the story is both a mystery and a philosophical puzzle. [An] / [CO3]

21. R. Austin Freeman, in “The Art of the Detective Story” criticizes the use of false clues or red herrings in detective stories because they deceive the reader instead of engaging them in fair reasoning. He insists that detective fiction should be based on fair play — the

reader must have access to all the real clues needed to solve the mystery. False clues, he argues, weaken logic, create artificial suspense, and make the story depend on tricks rather than intellect. Freeman believes a good writer can maintain suspense by presenting true clues clearly but subtly, trusting the reader to mislead themselves through misinterpretation. He sees false clues as a mark of poor technique and "bad practice" because they destroy the intellectual satisfaction that defines genuine detective fiction.

[E] / [CO1]

22. **Lenient evaluation recommended.** In "The Purloined Letter," Dupin solves the mystery by imagining how the criminal thinks. Poe shows that real detection is not just about logic but about understanding the human mind. Dupin succeeds because he uses both reason and imagination. The police search every corner mechanically, but Dupin realises that the clever Minister D would hide the letter in the most obvious place — right in front of everyone. Poe uses this moment to show that intelligence alone is not enough; what matters is the ability to think creatively and to read the psychology of others. Dupin succeeds because he understands pride, vanity, and the habits of the human mind. The story becomes more than a puzzle — it's about how imagination can uncover truth when reason fails. [E] / [CO2]

23. **Lenient evaluation recommended.** "A Study in Pink" is a modern story that changes the old idea of moral certainty. Sherlock uses reason without emotion, while the killer believes he is doing moral work by punishing the corrupt. Both act from belief, not pure good or evil. Both follow their own rules. The cab driver kills people as part of a strange and deadly game. He offers his victims two pills — one harmless and one poisoned — claiming that if they choose the wrong one, it's their fate. The story shows that truth and justice are complex, and the ending doesn't give clear justice. Holmes wins through logic, but the moral result is uncertain, making viewers question what is truly right. It shows that modern detective stories explore moral doubt as much as they solve crime. It reveals a world where human choices are complex and morality depends on perspective rather than fixed rules. [U] / [CO3]

[15x2 = 30]